

Chapter 31_1 - Crimson

Feng Ge's face changed, and she immediately bowed respectfully: "Greetings to Divine Venerable Chu Ling."

Ning Fuyi swallowed the unspoken words in her mouth, blinked, and turned around.

It really was Chu Qingqiu. She had already changed into an ink-wash painting-like dress, mostly white mixed with layers of elegant black. The wind lifted her hem, dreamlike and illusory. The white bone hung at her waist, accentuating her slender figure.

She obviously had no trace of drunkenness left. Those eyes looked at Feng Ge without emotion, and several people suddenly fell into silence.

Feng Ge didn't know what she had done wrong, but under such a gaze, she broke out in a cold sweat and couldn't help but lower her head even more.

"Come here." After Chu Qingqiu spoke, she didn't glance at Ning Fuyi and turned to leave the noisy crowd.

Ning Fuyi was still in a daze when Liu Wenzhu beside her quickly pushed her, nearly making her fall off the white jade platform: "The Divine Venerable is calling you, hurry!"

She borrowed this momentum and stumbled after Chu Qingqiu, following her to stand before the cliff where clouds rolled under the gaze of everyone.

From time to time, other disciples' gazes noticed this place, discussing quietly among themselves.

"Having low cultivation is really good—can't sword-fly but gets to ride the Divine Venerable's spirit beast." Someone clicked their tongue in admiration. "Not like us, having to fly over ourselves."

"Where do you have her good fortune? Though she has no talent, she's the daughter of our former sect master, and speaking of it, she's still a young sect master. What's the relationship between the former sect master and the Divine Venerable? Those who understand will understand." Another person sneered.

"Hey, that's not right. Didn't rumors say that Divine Venerable Chu Ling never gave her a second glance?"

"Nonsense!" Hong Ying's rough voice rang out, and the disciples immediately fell silent. Hong Ying's gaze toward Ning Fuyi was also unfriendly, but he still fulfilled his duty as a managing disciple and scolded them into silence.

Ning Fuyi caught all these words with the southeast wind.

"If you care about these things, go find Rong Jin¹." Chu Qingqiu, standing in the wind, suddenly spoke. Large masses of clouds swept past beneath her feet, wetting her hem.

The little white tiger leaped out from the prayer bead on her wrist, instantly transforming to its original form—white forehead with hanging eyes², mouth like an abyss, tail like a steel whip reaching to heaven, hanging powerfully beneath its body.

Bai Lin suddenly opened its bloody maw, and its tiger roar traveled through the mountains, frightening the disciples into stepping back.

"The Divine Venerable jests." Ning Fuyi wasn't frightened by Bai Lin. Instead, she curved her phoenix eyes and, under everyone's gaze, leaped up and brazenly jumped onto Bai Lin's back.

This made the other disciples even more envious and indignant, with complaints rising and falling. Seeing this scene, Ning Fuyi simply leaned into Bai Lin's fur, crossed her legs, and lay down comfortably, infuriating people without compensation.

Seeing this, Chu Qingqiu concealed the momentary gleam in her eyes. Her body transformed into flying feathers, and the next instant she stood on Bai Lin's spine. With another tiger roar, Bai Lin's massive body soared into the air and disappeared behind the distant mountains.

Ning Fuyi nearly got thrown off by the sudden acceleration. She no longer dared to lie down and quickly grabbed Bai Lin's fur with both hands, turning to sit up. The wind blew her hair wildly across her face. Ning Fuyi cursed silently, hurriedly shaking off her hair, only to be slapped in the face by her own sleeves.

Just as she was in distress, her body seemed wrapped in a warm film. The fierce wind immediately ceased around her, and her wildly flying hair slowly settled down.

Ning Fuyi breathed a sigh of relief, released her tightly gripping hands, untangled her hair, and casually pinned it up with a hairpin.

When she looked up, Chu Qingqiu stood steadily in place, not even her hem disturbed. Ning Fuyi coughed and touched her face.

"Where are the gate robes?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

"They weren't comfortable to wear, so I didn't wear them." Ning Fuyi lied. She struggled to stand up steadily. At this time, Bai Lin had already flown a hundred li, and the mountains and rivers beneath her feet were completely new. A long river she had never seen before surged across the plains, rushing toward the distance.

Chu Qingqiu made an "mm" sound, her expression unreadable.

"The Divine Venerable could obviously order others to do it, so why do it personally?" Ning Fuyi couldn't help but ask.

"Rong Jin's mouth can be dispensed with." Chu Qingqiu spoke, her gaze fixed straight ahead at the sea of clouds. "This venerable said I would fulfill my promise to Ning Changfeng."

"Besides asking you to teach me, did her dying wish also ask you to make clothes for me?" Ning Fuyi raised an eyebrow.

Chu Qingqiu's red lips moved but remained speechless for a moment.

Having already guessed that she wouldn't get anything out of Chu Qingqiu's mouth, Ning Fuyi waved her sleeve: "Fine, fine. A promise is a promise. Thank you."

Chu Qingqiu didn't speak, and Ning Fuyi said nothing more, only focusing on watching the changing scenery below. After an unknown amount of time, a blast of air suddenly exploded on Bai Lin's back. Thanks to Chu Qingqiu's protective magic, Ning Fuyi wasn't blown away by this air blast.

Chu Qingqiu seemed accustomed to such entrances and merely raised her sleeve to block the wind.

A tall figure appeared between the two of them. Qiu Yi, wearing green gate robes, landed steadily, just putting away the curved blade she had been stepping on. Just as she was about to bow to Chu Qingqiu, she suddenly turned around, shocked: "Ning Fuyi? Why are you here!"

"What, is Bai Lin yours to raise?" Ning Fuyi retorted, leaning back again with her hands behind her head, looking very comfortable.

"You! Master, she..." Qiu Yi was so angry that her hair nearly stood on end. However, Chu Qingqiu only glanced at her lightly, and her bristling fur settled back down.

"Reporting to Master." She didn't dare make a fuss anymore and could only suppress her resentment, speaking quietly: "The elders and disciples have already departed. Sword flight takes a long time—it will take two days to reach Swaggering Mountain. Should we wait for them, or go ahead first?"

"Let's go slowly. After all, I currently hold the title of sect master. Arriving too early wouldn't look good." Chu Qingqiu said, and Bai Lin beneath her feet slowed down.

"Yes, Master." Qiu Yi glanced at Chu Qingqiu, then at Ning Fuyi who was squinting and smiling at her. Unable to bear it, she strode to Ning Fuyi's side and sat down hard, trying to squeeze her to the edge.

Ning Fuyi was much more slender than her and knew she couldn't overpower her in a collision. She suddenly stood up nimbly. Qiu Yi used too much force and, with an "aiya," buried her head in Bai Lin's fur.

Ning Fuyi looked at her and clicked her tongue twice, then unhurriedly walked around to her other side and sat down slowly again.

Qiu Yi was already hot-tempered, and being provoked like this made her even angrier. She pulled her head out and was about to argue when Chu Qingqiu suddenly coughed lightly, and she immediately fell silent.

"My master pities you, so she helps you. Don't get too pleased with yourself." She suppressed her belly full of anger and said in a low voice.

Ning Fuyi shook her head noncommittally, too lazy to argue with Qiu Yi anymore. Facing the warm sunlight, she simply lay down, took out a handkerchief from her storage pouch to cover her face, and entered dreamland.

Bai Lin flew extremely steadily. After an unknown amount of time, Ning Fuyi finally woke up, drowsily lifting the handkerchief from her eyes.

The warm wind was blowing. Qiu Yi beside her had also fallen asleep, curled up in a ball with her head pillowed on her arm. Chu Qingqiu stood in a place farther from them, holding the white bone in her hand as flute sounds trickled out.

Reaching her ears, it was inexplicably sorrowful.

Ning Fuyi didn't understand music and couldn't tell what tune she was playing. She only felt that the flute sound seemed like weeping, so after listening for a while, she stopped. She reached into her pouch and took out a hard cake wrapped in oil paper, chewing it dryly.

Qiu Yi had long since achieved fasting³ and didn't need to eat, and Chu Qingqiu even less so. So Ning Fuyi hadn't expected these two to land and rest for her.

Fortunately, she had been thoughtful and taken a few white flour cakes from the dining hall when she came. Though they weren't tasty, at least she wouldn't starve to death.

She just brought too little water. Ning Fuyi chewed with effort, feeling her jaw ache.

As she was having an intense battle with the white flour cake alone, she suddenly felt Bai Lin beneath her slow down even more, seemingly gradually descending. The mountains, rivers, and towns below grew larger and larger, and soon she could see the towering city gate towers clearly.

At this time, Qiu Yi had also awakened. She opened her eyes and looked down, quickly standing up: "Master, we are..."

"There's a town below. We're passing by, so let's land and rest." Chu Qingqiu put away the white bone.

"But..." Qiu Yi was somewhat puzzled. "This distance is nothing to Bai Lin. Why..."

"Bai Lin can travel ten thousand li in a day. In just half a day, we could reach Swaggering Mountain. Even if we slow down, it's still one day. Rather than circling in the sky waiting for them, it's better to find a place to rest." Chu Qingqiu said.

"I see." Qiu Yi looked enlightened. "This disciple spoke too much."

Ning Fuyi, listening to their conversation from the side, stared intently at Chu Qingqiu, always feeling that when the other spoke those words, her gaze wasn't so certain.

However, this move was in no way bad for her. Ning Fuyi rubbed her aching jaw from chewing and cheerfully threw the cake with several tooth marks back into her pouch.

Below was the mortal world, and it looked like a prosperous place at that. There would be plenty of delicious things, much better than sitting in the wind gnawing on cakes!

Bai Lin naturally didn't dare land in the city, so while still in mid-air, it transformed into a white tiger and dove into a prayer bead. Ning Fuyi suddenly plummeted, and just as she was about to cry out, someone grabbed her collar, suspending her in mid-air as they descended.

Being strangled by her collar around the neck felt uncomfortable. Ning Fuyi quickly hugged the waist of the person beside her. Before she could marvel at how slender that waist was, her hand was firmly slapped, and she had to withdraw it with a red face.

Chu Qingqiu immediately let go the next instant, and Ning Fuyi suddenly fell.

Fortunately, she was quick-eyed and quick-handed, summoning her immortal power to cushion her feet, thus avoiding a fall on all fours.

After she stood steady, Chu Qingqiu slowly descended, her toes lightly touching the grass leaves. Without even glancing at her, she flicked her sleeve and walked away, leaving Ning Fuyi to curse quietly in place.

"Really Divine Venerable temperament—touching once won't kill you." She helplessly rubbed her reddened neck and lifted her legs to follow.

The city before them was indeed a central city. Even before entering, there were already signs of heavy traffic. Most of the passersby were merchants' carriages or foreign visitors passing through the city. Within a hundred li outside the city, everything seemed like it was within the city. A long river passed through the city, and to enter the city, one had to cross a bridge first. Both on and under the bridge were crowded and bustling—people coming and going on the bridge, while dark-covered boats shuttled beneath.

The three emerged from a secluded place and soon blended into the passing common people.

Fortunately, this city was wealthy, and most pedestrians wore brocade and fine clothes. Even if they weren't from wealthy families, their clothing was of good material. The three walking among them wouldn't be too conspicuous.

However, not being conspicuous in clothing didn't mean other things weren't conspicuous. The three were women traveling together, and their appearances were all first-rate. As they walked, they attracted quite a few gazes.

Ning Fuyi and Qiu Yi were still manageable, but mainly Chu Qingqiu—her ink-wash dress was already outstanding, plus her hair like a waterfall and graceful bearing. A face that would be hard to find even among immortals, placed among mortals, could hardly avoid attracting attention.

The three walked into the city, which lived up to the prosperity displayed outside. It could truly be said that the eight streets and nine markets⁴ were bustling with voices. However, wherever Chu Qingqiu passed, people would gather more, causing them to have walked only half a street before they could no longer move forward.

"What are you looking at, what are you looking at!" Qiu Yi shouted angrily. She glared fiercely, putting on a menacing appearance, finally driving the nearby onlookers aside and barely clearing a path.

"Master, the folk customs here are really open. In broad daylight, they dare to surround and stare at a woman like this, completely different from our Cang Yun⁵." Qiu Yi muttered, then suddenly shouted again: "Stop looking, go away!"

Although Chu Qingqiu had seen everything, she rarely wandered in the mortal world and had never seen such bold folk customs. Being in the mortal realm, she couldn't easily use her immortal power. For a moment, she felt constrained and could only dodge when encountering people.

A rare trace of indignation appeared in those usually cold eyes.

Ning Fuyi, however, walked behind them with her arms akimbo, quite enjoying watching Chu Qingqiu's restrained appearance.

"Master, this seems to be a teahouse. Why don't we go in and sit? Looking at the current situation, I'm afraid we won't be able to continue walking." Qiu Yi said with a bitter face.

She could see people swarming toward them from all directions, mostly young men excitedly whispering to each other while crowding forward like bees.

"These people act like they've never seen a woman in their lives!" Qiu Yi was so angry she felt dizzy. But unable to actually attack mortals, she could only clear the way in front, pulling Chu Qingqiu and diving into the teahouse to escape the crowd.

Watching the two of them fleeing like refugees, Ning Fuyi nearly laughed out loud. She used her shoulder to push through those people and followed them inside.

"Excuse me, excuse me." She shouted while driving them away, struggling to enter the teahouse's private room under the waiter's guidance.

Chu Qingqiu had already taken a seat, the indignation still not faded from her expression. Seeing Ning Fuyi enter with barely suppressed laughter, the anger in her heart intensified.

"Sit down." She said coldly, putting down the teacup in her hand heavily, splashing out some tea.

Ning Fuyi pretended to be serious, suppressing her laughter as she sat down. Just then, someone opened the door to enter but was frightened by Chu Qingqiu's angry shout, nearly falling over.

"Get out!" Chu Qingqiu gritted her teeth.

The person held onto the door frame for a long time before showing his face with an embarrassed smile, saying carefully: "Miss, this humble one is a waiter from this teahouse, here to deliver the menu for ordering, not one of those onlookers."

Ning Fuyi nearly couldn't hold it together again. Even Qiu Yi turned away, covering her mouth and pretending nothing had happened.

Chu Qingqiu's fair face darkened. She exhaled heavily and waved for him to enter.

Only then did the waiter bow and enter, placing the menu on the table with his head lowered, not daring to look too much.

"You look." Chu Qingqiu threw the menu in front of Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi wasn't polite either. She picked it up and read several dish names. After the waiter took back the menu, Chu Qingqiu took out a piece of water jade⁶ from her sleeve, about to hand it to him, but Ning Fuyi quickly pressed her hand down.

Their hands touched inadvertently. Chu Qingqiu's hand was warm, Ning Fuyi's cooler. Both paused, and Chu Qingqiu immediately withdrew her hand.

"Thank you." Ning Fuyi took out a few taels of silver from her pouch and placed them in the waiter's hand, asking with a smile: "We're travelers passing through this place. May I know what this city is called and why it's so... crowded?"

She used "crowded" to summarize the chaos from earlier.

The waiter was naturally delighted to receive the silver, placing both hands on his stomach: "This is Dongyang City⁷. The mountains are rich and waters beautiful, and it's connected to the canal, so it's always been prosperous. The folk customs are also open. There are many young men and women, and normally they have the custom of throwing fresh flowers to those they admire. So when they rarely see such beautiful ladies like you, word spreads quickly."

"Miss need not worry. Although Dongyang City has open folk customs, the people are law-abiding and won't harm you."

"Understood. You may go." Ning Fuyi said.

After the waiter left, Ning Fuyi smiled again: "One can tell at a glance that the Divine Venerable has cultivated for years without knowing worldly affairs. This is the mortal realm—we spend silver, not water jade."

Chu Qingqiu made an "oh" sound and put away the water jade.

The food came quickly. Ning Fuyi, who had been hungry all along the way, began eating heartily, while Chu Qingqiu and Qiu Yi only drank tea beside her. Chu Qingqiu was fine, but Qiu Yi soon felt bored. She got up and looked out the window for a while, then carefully requested: "Master, I see it's really prosperous outside, very much like Cang Yun. I'd like to..."

"Go ahead." Before she could finish, Chu Qingqiu nodded in agreement.

"Thank you, Master!" Qiu Yi immediately beamed with joy and quickly walked out the door.

Ning Fuyi swallowed a mouthful of hot porridge and looked up at Qiu Yi's retreating figure, asking: "Divine Venerable, what is Cang Yun?"

"Qiu Yi's hometown." Chu Qingqiu didn't hide it.

Ning Fuyi had heard of this place before—it was a small country near the Western Wasteland⁸.

So Qiu Yi wasn't a descendant of immortals but came from the mortal world. Ning Fuyi understood but didn't ask further.

After eating and drinking her fill, she put down her chopsticks and bowl. Looking up, she found that Chu Qingqiu had begun meditating at some point, and Qiu Yi hadn't returned yet, so she also stood up.

"Where are you going?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

"To buy some food and water to take along. Otherwise, when we continue traveling later, I'll have to go hungry again." Ning Fuyi replied. She wasn't willing to eat those unpalatable white flour cakes again.

Seeing that Chu Qingqiu didn't object, she pushed open the door and walked out.

So only Chu Qingqiu remained in the room. She meditated for another half hour but didn't see the two return. The sun overhead had already passed its zenith, and it was clear that noon had passed.

How worrisome they were. Chu Qingqiu kept a straight face as she stood up, closed her eyes to probe with her divine consciousness, and found that both were not nearby. So she grasped the white bone, clasped her hands behind her back, and walked out of the room, preparing to look for them.

But just as she walked out of the teahouse, she saw the crowd swarming toward her. Chu Qingqiu was greatly alarmed. She wanted to use her immortal power to block them but couldn't. In an instant, she was surrounded by the crowd.

The smell of sweat and cosmetics from people's bodies mixed together, making her dizzy. People kept saying things to her, and the bold ones stuffed fresh flowers and purses into her hands. Words were useless, and she couldn't resort to violence, making her angry and uncomfortable. She could only keep dodging.

"Make way!" She frowned and scolded, just avoiding one person when another group rushed up from her side, with nowhere to hide.

Just as she was getting annoyed, a figure suddenly emerged from behind her, pushing others away while smoothly placing something over her head. Her vision was immediately occupied by white gauze.

The hand securing the hat landed on her head, transmitting a soft touch. Chu Qingqiu's dodging steps stopped.

"After walking away for just a while, the Divine Venerable is so popular again?" Ning Fuyi appeared in front of her, one hand helping her secure the hat, the other gently lifting the veil, smiling.

However, this smile quickly stiffened somewhat, because she seemed to see that Chu Qingqiu, who never smiled or laughed, had on her face...

A quickly rising blush of crimson.

Footnotes:

1. **Rong Jin (容锦)** - Ning Fuyi's senior brother, literally means "Tolerate Brocade"
2. **Hanging eyes (吊睛白额)** - A traditional description of a tiger's appearance, referring to the distinctive eye shape and white forehead markings
3. **Fasting (辟谷)** - A cultivation practice where advanced practitioners no longer need to eat regular food, sustaining themselves through spiritual energy
4. **Eight streets and nine markets (八街九陌)** - A classical Chinese expression describing a bustling commercial area with many streets and markets
5. **Cang Yun (苍云)** - Qiu Yi's homeland, literally means "Gray/Blue Clouds"
6. **Water jade (水玉)** - A type of precious stone or spiritual currency used by immortals
7. **Dongyang City (东阳城)** - The city they're visiting, literally means "Eastern Sun City"
8. **Western Wasteland (西荒)** - A geographical region, likely a barren or less civilized area to the west